



Drifting with the tide

Like many sea creatures, brittle stars live on the seafloor as adults but spend the early part of their lives as plankton—tiny organisms that float freely in the sunlit upper waters of the ocean. They drift with the currents for weeks, traveling hundreds of miles before finally sinking to the seafloor, where they change into adult brittle stars.

LIVING RELATIVE

Around 2,000 species of brittle star exist today, in icy seas and warm waters all over the world. These, often brilliantly colored, creatures—some with patterned bodies—have five snakelike arms. When attacked, they shed an arm, which wriggles for a while, confusing the predator. Brittle stars quickly regrow the lost arm.

